



Goethe's *Faust* and the Absolute of *Naturphilosophie*

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This article approaches the concept of the absolute operative in Goethe's *Faust* by taking its point of departure from Schelling's *Naturphilosophie*, which supersedes and embeds tragic subjectivity in an ontological dynamic that both grounds and exceeds the subjective. The essential operations of such an absolute manifest themselves in the tensions and inconsistencies generated by dynamic forces—attraction and repulsion, contraction and expansion—that move through all appearances, whether material, psychic, or discursive. Because a chaotic reserve of disorder belongs intrinsically to the unfolding of the absolute of *Naturphilosophie*, absolute signification in *Faust* manifests itself primarily in the shape of aberrant destinies. Moreover, the transcendental and textual dynamics of attraction and repulsion produce operations of *unconditioning* (from the “conditionlessness” of the absolute, *das Unbedingte*) such that no singular phenomenon or individuated being can become a prioritized representative of the absolute. This article thus attempts to “uncondition” Faustian striving by drawing attention to alternative models of absolute signification in the text—for example, to Homunculus (the absolute as disindividuation), Euphorion (hyperindividuation), Gretchen (heteronomous-ethical individuation), or Mephistopheles (the negation of individuation)—each of whom are differentiated but nevertheless share the dynamic of forces of attraction and repulsion through which the movement of the absolute discloses itself. Finally, the paper seeks to “uncondition” the Eternal Feminine—itself an inconsistent, queer manifestation of the absolute (since it operates not just on male subjects, but on female subjects and angels that perturb sexual differentiation)—and open the path to an *exteriority* to the narrative of redemption, one that calls into question the Eternal Feminine as a full, adequate representation of the textual cosmology of *Faust*.

Keywords: aesthetics, *Faust*, Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, *Naturphilosophie*, ontology, Friedrich Schelling

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GOETHE AND ABSOLUTE SIGNIFICATION

Goethe's *Faust* may be regarded as an aesthetic exercise organized around the notion of an ontological absolute: a field of being that extends over the totality of entities and permeates the motion of their movements. This tendency toward the absolute is often signaled by Faust himself, whether in his desire to know what holds all things together—"Daß ich erkenne was die Welt / Im Innersten zusammenhält" (382)—or, once he has been healed from his drive to knowledge (*Wissensdrang*), through his aim to expand the boundaries of finitude: "Und was der ganzen Menschheit zugeteilt ist, / Will ich in meinem innern Selbst genießen" (1770–71).¹ With this declaration, Faust marks a shift in the form of desire spawned by the imagination of an absolute, altering its scope from the recognition of an inner principle of ontological coherence to an immanent, embodied totality of possible human experiences.

The Faustian absolute posits a tragic structure common to human experience in a form of subjectivity that is always striving to go beyond its own limits, and thereby doomed (or blessed) to perpetually miss its mark.² With *Faust II*, however, Goethe moves beyond the confines of subjectivity and explores a more capacious conception of the absolute. This article attempts to approach the absolute in Goethe's *Faust* by taking its point of departure from Schelling's *Naturphilosophie*.

The essential operations of a naturephilosophical absolute manifest themselves in the tensions and inconsistencies generated by dynamic forces—attraction and repulsion, contraction and expansion—that move through all appearances, whether material, psychic, or discursive. If *Faust I* dramatizes the dynamics of a form of subjectivity that posits its own tragic structure as the absolute, *Faust II* then integrates this drama into a broader ontology, just as Schelling's *Naturphilosophie* seeks to account for the emergence of a Fichtean notion of the absolute ego as the higher potentiation of a physical world ultimately irreducible to subjectivity. The absolute of *Naturphilosophie* in *Faust* should thus be regarded as an attempt to supersede and embed tragic subjectivity in an ontological dynamic that both grounds and exceeds the subjective: an ontology within which tragic subjectivity appears as one possible form of being rather than as a totalizing structure of being as such.³

Naturphilosophie in this instance functions not merely as a discourse or a codification of knowledge, but enables a specific interpretive practice. Reading the world through

¹All citations to Goethe are taken from the *Frankfurter Ausgabe*: Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, *Sämtliche Werke: Briefe, Tagebücher und Gespräche*, ed. Hendrik Birus, Dieter Borchmeyer, Karl Eibl, Wilhem Voßkamp, et al. (Frankfurt am Main: Deutscher Klassiker Verlag, 1985–2003). Numbers indicate part, volume number followed by page number. Citations to *Faust* refer to line numbers from the edition by Albrecht Schöne (FA I.7).

²Such an insight leads Wellbery to note that, for Fichte, "menschliche Erfahrung" is "ihrer Struktur nach transgressiv." David Wellbery, *Goethes Faust I: Reflexion der tragischen Form* (Munich: Carl Friedrich von Siemens Stiftung: 2016), 66. According to Wellbery, *Faust I* unlocks generic potential of tragedy in its overarching disclosure of the tragedy of subjectivity.

³If interpreters typically understand the movement from *Faust I* to *Faust II* as a movement from "individual" to "cosmos," the *cosmos* must not just be opposed to the individual, but account for the continued dynamic of individuation; see Karl Eibl, *Das monumentale Ich: Wege zu Goethes "Faust"* (Frankfurt am Main: Insel, 2000), 166.

the lens of *Naturphilosophie* entails an attentiveness to the presence of heterogeneity in the order of the sensible: how one zone always limits and conditions another. The result of such a naturephilosophical manner of reading is that the figure of Faust no longer becomes the singular vehicle of absolute striving or a paradigmatic model to be emulated. This practice invokes what Iain Hamilton Grant has called the process of *unconditioning* (from the “conditionlessness” of the absolute, *das Unbedingte*) such that no singular phenomenon or individuated being can become a prioritized representative of the absolute.⁴

Critics may thereby “uncondition” Faustian striving by drawing attention to alternative models of individuation in the text—for example, to Gretchen, Homunculus, Euphorion, or Mephistopheles—each of whom are differentiated but nevertheless share the dynamic of forces of attraction and repulsion through which the movement of the absolute discloses itself. Indeed, one may go so far as to “uncondition” the Eternal Feminine—which is in any case, as we shall see, an inconsistent, queer manifestation of the absolute—and open the path to an *exteriority* to the narrative of redemption, one that calls into question any individuated field of attractions and repulsions as a full, adequate representation of the textual cosmology or ontology articulated in *Faust*.

Although I draw on *Naturphilosophie* as an ontological model through which to approach the strategic aesthetic interventions of *Faust*, the following thoughts are not intended to be exhaustive interpretations of what the text is but generative and tentative explorations of what the text could be. My readings are thus not likely to conform to the expectations established by a specifically “naturphilosophische Lesart.”⁵ I do not proceed by looking for the positivistic or scientific sources for textual phenomena—in discourses of geology, morphology, electricity, magnetism, or by any discourse that could anchor such an inquiry in the principles of polarity (*Polarität*) and intensification (*Steigerung*)—but by following the sensuous specificity of the work of art as it generates its own attractions and repulsions, heterogeneities and homogeneities, focusing on the manner in which the order and disorder of beings is manifested within or translated into aesthetic form.

Schelling’s own *Philosophie der Kunst* draws on the ontology of *Naturphilosophie* in order to rethink aesthetic signification in this manner.⁶ In the *Philosophie der Kunst*, Schelling lays the preparatory grounds for a new mythology based not on Christianity and

⁴Iain Hamilton Grant designates “Schellingianism” as the “philosophical project of *unconditioning* the metaphysics of nature.” Iain Hamilton Grant, *Philosophies of Nature After Schelling* (New York: Continuum, 2006), 6. Unconditioning refers all schemata of differentiation back to a dynamic and generative process of self-construction such that no particular element or discrete domain can determine what counts as inside or outside a system; all that is (as we shall see, even that which is outside the Eternal Feminine) reveals the self-construction of this naturephilosophical absolute. One may thus *uncondition* the Eternal Feminine itself inasmuch as it tries to establish conditions on the unconditioned.

⁵For a good example of such a “naturphilosophische Lesart”—which does indeed pose questions akin to those that I am asking, while considering the source material for organizational patterns in the text based on “Polarität” and “Steigerung”—see Ulrich Gaier, *Lesarten von Goethes Faust* (Eggingen: Klaus Isele, 2012), 219–64.

⁶My own interpretation of *Faust* differs from Schelling’s in the *Philosophie der Kunst* (informed by the fragments to which he had access) as the portrayal of one who “durch Erhebung über sich selbst und das Unwesentliche das Wesentliche schaut und genießen lernt” (SW 1.5.733). Citations to Schelling’s works

its signifying tendencies—not on a pure *allegoresis* in which the reality of the finite particular disappears in the transcendence of infinite generality—but on a symbolic-speculative physics according to which the particular recursively produces the absolute.⁷ *Faust II* represents one vision of what such a speculative-physical mythology could resemble. According to this form of semiosis, when a poetic work of art reproduces the movements of the absolute, language no longer functions as a medium. As the concrete embodiment of a process of indifferentiation (which refers to a paradoxical operation that simultaneously suspends and maintains differences) between the real and the ideal, language *is* the absolute as infinite, productive process. Art is not mediation; it is immediation. Schelling calls this form of language “poesy” in contradistinction to mere speech, indicating with this term the most potentiated, highly developed, and revelatory form of a dynamic internal to material nature *and* conscious ideality. According to Schelling, “Die Sprache als die sich *lebendig* aussprechende unendliche Affirmation ist das höchste Symbol des Chaos, das in dem absoluten Erkennen auf ewige Weise liegt” (SW 1.5.484).

If the naturephilosophical absolute enters into existence in order to ultimately affirm its own self-organization, then it must simultaneously affirm the inhuman and extranormative domain of chaos that inheres in both organic life and inorganic matter. To put the point somewhat polemically: because the chaotic reserve of disorder belongs intrinsically to the unfolding of the absolute, Goethe's *Faust* posits that which is monstrous or deviant as that which is also to be affirmed. Such instances of absolute signification manifest themselves primarily in the shape of aberrant destinies. *Faust* constitutes a veritable compendium of figures of normative inversion and transgression: Faust, Margarete, Homunculus, Helen, Euphorion, and Mephistopheles, to name the most prominent examples. By according to each figure in the text a specific revelatory capacity, we confront instances of signification whereby that which is *outside* normativity, or normalization as such, becomes a constitutive feature of the order of textual appearances. To discover the more capacious scope of the underlying ontology of *Faust*, however, one must decenter the tragedy away from the figure of Faust and understand the other figures of the drama as offering alternative models of being (or non-being) within this broader framework.

are taken from Friedrich Schelling, *Sämmtliche Werke*, ed. Karl Friedrich August Schelling (Stuttgart and Augsburg, Cotta: 1858). Parenthetical citations indicate part number, volume number, and page number.

⁷“Nicht wir wollen der idealistischen Bildung ihre Götter durch die *Physik* geben. Wir erwarten vielmehr ihre Götter, für die wir [...] die Symbole schon in Bereitschaft haben” (SW. 1.5.449). Speculative physics does not simply negate Christianity but effaces Christianity (and specifically its allegorical tendencies) as an opposition, regarding its oppositionality as a period of transition that will be surpassed. Schelling writes, “Alle speculative Philosophie hat nothwendig dieselbe der Richtung des Christenthums entgegengesetzte Richtung, sofern man nämlich das Christenthum in dieser seiner empirisch-historischen Gestalt nimmt, in welcher es sich als Gegensatz darstellt, und nicht in dieser Entgegensetzung es selbst als Uebergang betrachtet” (SW 1.5.448). For Schelling, the ground for the gods to come prepared by *Naturphilosophie* overcomes the Christian allegorical conception of language in which the reality of the finite particular disappears in the transcendence of the infinite generality.

THE AGONISTIC ONTOLOGY OF *NATURPHILOSOPHIE*

At the end of *Faust II*, we find ourselves in a space at once familiar and strange, with tensions and velocities that are not simply—as in Dante’s *Divine Comedy*—the manifestation of an erotic force, *l’amor che move il sole e l’altre stelle*, drawing figures upward or moving with a harmonious circular motion. This space is populated by swaying entities, by forward, backward, downward, upward, curving, rotating motion, each figure with its particular velocity, direction, and stasis: they are heavenly beings, but we are not in heaven, remaining resolutely on earth, among mountain gorges, *Bergschluchten*. The topography of mountain gorges, combining both *Berg* (mountain) and *Schlucht* (ravine), enacts a spatial translation of opposing forces, an agonistic nexus of pulls moving in different directions: the upward trajectory of the mountain fused with the downward slope, indeed, the abyssal nature of the canyon. The tapering points of peak and abyss are placed on a continuum.

The temporality of this moment in the drama is just as concentrated with opposing forces as is the spatiality of the mountain ravines. For Faust, this moment condenses beginning, ending, and a perpetual motion that belies the very categories of beginning and ending. Faust, divested from a body, appears here without language and has thus become an *infans* (infant), at the origin of the trajectory of a life; at the same time, he is already surpassing the other heavenly children in his accelerated development, as one who, yet again, is always on the move. The line of flight taken by Faust’s “immortal part” (*Unsterbliches*) reproduces the dynamic that permeated his life: here is another space to cross.

We would be making a grave error, however, to confuse Faust’s particular trajectory with the order of the cosmic system as such. The *chorus mysticus*, in the final lines of the drama, presents as a cosmic rule neither a Fichtean inflected striving nor a Dantean metaphysics of love, but the bare presence of an attraction, an *Anziehungskraft*: “Das Ewig-Weibliche / Zieht uns hinan” (12110–1). To focus solely on the hypostatization of the ideal in this phrase, *das Ewig-Weibliche*, threatens to obscure the dynamics of the absolute to be found in the verb *hinzuziehen*, which indicates a far more pervasive concept for the absolute motion subtending the cosmos of *Faust*. Moreover, as we shall see, the notion of attraction indicated by *hinzuziehen* is not necessarily operative only in the form of binary structures that could, for example, stabilize the difference between male and female.

Although it is tempting to portray the final lines of *Faust* as a form of Neo-Platonic or Dantean erotic ascent (albeit one that never fully divests itself of the sensuous, spatio-temporal world), the dynamics of attractive force differ in fundamental ways from that of love or desire.⁸ At the most basic physical or material level, force as attraction describes a dynamic relation between at least two points, or the motion of these points in relation to one another. Repulsion, above all from the perspective of *Naturphilosophie*, exists equiprimordially in tension with the force of attraction and is itself constitutive of textual, material, and ontological order. Kant, in his *Metaphysische Anfangsgründe der Naturwissenschaft*, had already portrayed the struggle of these forces with one another as an internal principle

⁸ Compare, for example, Jochen Schmidt’s interpretation of the final scene as an instantiation of Platonic love. Jochen Schmidt, *Goethes Faust, Erster und Zweiter Teil. Grundlagen—Werk—Wirkung* (Munich: Beck, 1999), 289.

of matter.⁹ In Schelling's *Ideen zu einer Philosophie der Natur* (1797), attraction and repulsion become the transcendental conditions of possibility for any system—whether inorganic, organic, or sentient—in which there is differentiation.¹⁰ Repulsion corresponds to an expansive, will-driven, outward movement in subjectivity that overcomes boundaries and seeks to impose itself on the external world; attraction impedes, blocks, and limits this tendency, thus accounting for the resistance encountered by the subject in its attempts at self-realization. Only in the interaction of both forces can a differentiated world—both material and ideal—come into being.

The interplay of attraction and repulsion—in which the residue of exteriority constitutes a necessary presence in a play of contradictory forces—thus becomes an internal principle of perception, of *aisthesis* in the fullest sense of the word, as sensuous cognition and aesthetic observation. Schelling writes:

Was man beym Anblick von Gebirgen, die in die Wolken sich verlieren, beym donnernden Sturz einer Katarrhakte, überhaupt bey allem, was groß und herrlich ist in der Natur, empfindet – jenes Anziehen und Zurückstoßen zwischen dem Gegenstand und dem betrachtenden Geist, jenen Streit entgegengesetzter Richtungen, den erst die Anschauung endet – alles das geht, nur transzendental und bewußtlos, bei der Anschauung überhaupt vor.¹¹

Attraction and repulsion, as transcendental operations, suture various heterogeneous domains together or hold them apart; in this instance, attraction and repulsion saturate the perceptual field of consciousness, thereby folding perception into the same processes that characterize the self-organization of matter. While attraction and repulsion begin as material transcendentials, they come to encompass psychic transcendentials (in the attempt of the ego to expand outward, or in a contraction inward when confronted with an exteriority), aesthetic transcendentials (as the identity and conflict between the real and the ideal in the work of art), and theological transcendentials—ultimately becoming commensurate with the transcendental-empirical order as such.¹² The development of the semantics of attractive and repulsive forces itself reveals an expansive and morphological drive within its own discursive configuration,

⁹Serenella Iovino writes that for Kant, “Diese Kräfte stellen das Verlangen der im Chaos verlorenen Materie nach seiner Form dar..., und in gewisser Weise verbindet sich so Spinozas Idee von der einzigen Substanz mit der des *conatus*.” Serenella Iovino, “‘Ich ist Nicht-Ich’ = ‘Alles ist Alles.’ Goethe als Leser der *Wissenschaftslehre*. Ein Beitrag zur Geschichte des Verhältnisses Fichte-Goethe,” *Fichte und die Literatur*, ed. Helmut Girndt and Klaus Hammacher (Amsterdam: Rodopi, 2002), 78.

¹⁰I have touched briefly on this relation in Gabriel Trop, “Poetry and Morphology: Goethe’s ‘Parabase’ and the Intensification of the Morphological Gaze,” *Monatshefte* 105.3 (Fall 2013): 389–406.

¹¹Schelling, *Ideen*, 140.

¹²In the *Freiheitsschrift*, the negating, contractive force of the ground is contrasted with the affirming, expansive force of existence; the creation emerges from the tension between the divine tendency that seeks to be absolutely one (analog of attraction) and the tendency toward self-affirmation that requires exteriorization (analog of repulsion).

moving through and thus fusing materialist, idealist, phenomenological, theological, and aesthetic operations.¹³

THE ABSOLUTE OF FORCE AND THE FORCE OF THE ABSOLUTE

In *Faust II* as in other works by Goethe, above all in *Die Wahlverwandtschaften*, the physical-transcendental forces of attraction and repulsion in various textual surfaces signal the presence of a heterodox ontology, or a differentiation of heterogeneous orders—for example, the co-presence of the normative (the ethical world order) and the extranormative (the daemonic).¹⁴ The total aesthetic system does not shy away from this differentiation between orders—which can sometimes agree, sometimes collide, and sometimes remain neutral with respect to one another—and gestures toward the affirmation of its own system as the production of textual agonisms.¹⁵

Let us now return to the end of *Faust II* through the lens of these operations of attraction. If Goethe's aesthetic practice consistently explores the ramifications of a naturephilosophical ontology that brings the ethical into contact with that which lies outside the ethical, the semantics of attraction—as the transcendental source of an affirmative form of signification—must be labile, capable of accommodating both order and chaos, ideality and sensuality. In the context of *Faust II*, such a form of signification appears precisely at the moment when the redemptive law of cosmic order is articulated. In this beginning/middle/end, angels, swaying in the higher atmosphere (*schwebend in der höhern Atmosphäre, Faustens Unsterbliches tragend*), recite the following lines:

Gerettet ist das edle Glied
Der Geisterwelt vom Bösen,
'Wer immer strebend sich bemüht
Den können wir erlösen.'
Und hat an ihm die Liebe gar

¹³Christoph Menke notes regarding the imbrication of force and aesthetics: "The issue of whether the internal principle of the movement in which sensible ideas are engendered must be thought of as a faculty of cognitive practices or as a force of unconscious expression is a contention that has riven the domain of aesthetics since its invention." Christoph Menke, *Force: A Fundamental Concept of Aesthetic Anthropology*, trans. Gerrit Jackson (New York: Fordham University Press, 2013), 12.

¹⁴Angus Nicholls writes: "The daemonic in Goethe is *a priori*, not in relation to a pure concept or category of the holy or numinous, but only in the sense that human rationality is limited by the modes of human cognition (as in Kant), and by the fact that reason is grounded in nature (as in Schelling)." Nicholls, *Goethe's Concept of the Daemonic* 234. One might then claim that the daemonic, like the absolute (which is not daemonic as such, since the daemonic is a mode of appearing, a phenomenology rather than an ontology), is simultaneously *a priori* and *a posteriori*: a transcendence and an immanence.

¹⁵The extent to which this total textual order is to be affirmed or negated cannot ultimately be included as immanent within the work; the text can only gesture toward this affirmation of existence in the final scene of *Faust* as part of a struggle or a textual agonistics. As I hope to show in the conclusion of this article, readings of *Faust* oscillate between an affirmation of the history of catastrophe or the catastrophe of a history of affirmation.

Von oben Teil genommen,
 Begegnet ihm die selige Schar
 Mit herzlichem Willkommen. (11934–41)

Here one senses the presence of opposing forces—up and down movements that do not quite cancel each other out but generate their own form of oscillation, indicated by the swaying (*schweben*) of the angels. Opposing forces may also be found in the language itself, as we are drawn across different linguistic registers. The lines contaminate the most ideal with the most vulgar; thus “Faustens Unsterbliches” is modeled on the form of the phallus (even if it is a disembodied phallus), *das edle Glied der Geisterwelt*, or the noble member of the spirit world (a member, incidentally, which Goethe had celebrated in certain suppressed Roman elegies).¹⁶ Faust’s member becomes bigger and more beautiful as it travels to a climax in the Eternal Feminine that is not truly a climax but just another attraction: an erotics without release. In what is likely a nod to Greek *eros*, the blessed boys, *die seligen Knaben*, are the figures most fixated on Faust’s phallic growth and self-multiplication; they note, “schon ist er schön und groß / Von heiligem Leben” (11988) and “er überwachst uns schon / An mächtigen Gliedern” (12076–7), signaling a latent homoeroticism that persists as an undercurrent even within a system organized by the Eternal Feminine as the seeming source of attractive power.¹⁷

A higher level of abstraction emerges alongside this phallic and sensuous erotic play in the semantics of an egocentric absolute idealism—a semantics to which Goethe was not oblivious, since he had read Fichte’s 1794 *Ueber den Begriff der Wissenschaftslehre* and had underlined certain concepts, notably that of *streben* (striving).¹⁸ In contrast to the relentless forward drive of the striving subject, *streben*, the angels hover or oscillate, *schweben*. The member (*Glied*) thus occupies a space that is one of simultaneous hovering and striving, *schweben* and *streben*. Indeed, Fichte’s *Wissenschaftslehre* understands the dynamic structure of the subject as a triangulated relation between striving, hovering, and members (*streben*, *schweben*, and *Glieder*), each of which represents a key term in the movements of the self-positing absolute ego. For Fichte, a *Glied* refers to any particular difference that appears in consciousness: a difference that makes a difference or a functional part that appears as part

¹⁶The poem “Hinten im Winkel des Gartens,” for example, initiates a sustained reflection on the poetic mediation of divine power and the divine mediation of poetic (and erotic) power. The poet can make a fallen god rise, and the god, through a phallic divine covenant, can make the poet rise.

¹⁷See Robert Tobin, *Warm Brothers: Queer Theory and the Age of Goethe* (Philadelphia: University of Philadelphia Press: 2000), 140–45.

¹⁸Géza von Molnár notes that Goethe underlined *streben* in his copy of Fichte’s essay. At the same time, he characterizes “das Ewig-Weibliche” as the “guiding principle that reaches beyond the phenomenal and pinpoints ‘das Unbeschreibliche’ to which all human effort at description pretends to refer.” Géza von Molnár, “Hidden in Plain View: Another Look at Goethe’s *Faust*,” *Goethe Yearbook* 11 (2002): 68. Viewing *das Ewig-Weibliche* as a manifestation of an ontology of attraction would posit this domain as simply one relatively homogeneous expression of an absolute that is essentially heterogeneous—always in the process of constructing itself by generating differences.

of the whole.¹⁹ *Schweben* refers to the action of the productive imagination, or the movements of the mind when it undertakes the impossible attempt to bind the manifold differences of the world into a synthetic whole; such an attempt culminates in an incomplete and perpetual oscillation, as „[der Geist] schwebt zwischen der Forderung [der Synthesis] und der Unmöglichkeit, sie zu erfüllen.“²⁰ *Streben* characterizes the ego inasmuch as it continually strives to assimilate and integrate all otherness into its own attempt to be perfectly autonomous and utterly identical with itself. Fichte writes: “Es thut in ihm [im Ich] sich eine Ungleichheit, und darum etwas fremdartiges hervor [...]. Dieses fremdartige steht nothwendig im Streite mit dem Streben des Ich, schlechthin identisch zu seyn.”²¹ In the mountain gorges, the structure of the absolute ego is saturated with phallic desire, as Faust’s immortal part couples both instinctuality and ideality.

At the end of his life, as has been noted in multiple commentaries, Faust embodies the most extreme form of this model of consciousness: self-totalization and self-aggrandizement such that everything outside of it, anything marked by foreignness, must be made into his own.²² Thus Faust seeks to appropriate the property, the tiny chapel and linden trees, of Baucis and Philemon, an old couple whose sedentary lifestyle exists in marked contrast to Faust’s perpetual motion: “Die Alten droben sollten weichen / Die Linden wünscht ich mir zum Sitz, / Die wenig Bäume, nicht mein eigen, / Verderben mir den Welt-Besitz” (11239–42). From the perspective of a naturephilosophical absolute, Baucis and Philemon align themselves more with a contractive tendency—remaining within delineated boundaries—rather than the expansive and often violent motion that drives Faust’s perpetual self-overcoming.

If we return to the dictum of the angels, *Wer immer strebend sich bemüht, / Den können wir erlösen*, we discover that Faust is redeemed not in spite of the violence he has committed—against Margarete, against Baucis and Philemon—but *because of it*, at least to the extent that this violence directed against otherness becomes commensurate with the act of striving. Cosmological order in this instance appears singularly beyond good and evil, dependent only on an affirmation of the very structure of consciousness as such. The criterion of possible redemption thus misfires as a criterion: every being that has self-consciousness and struggles to position itself (*sich setzen* may be rendered: to position oneself, to take a stand) can be redeemed. The radicality of this dictum consists in the positing of striving as purely formal, without any distinct normative content or force.

And yet: this striving must somehow prioritize being over its negation; Faust is redeemed to the extent that his experiential series makes manifest his restless life (or *lives*) as

¹⁹Such a functionalization of individual parts via local actions that would then play a role in the shaping of reality is exemplary of a metaphysical paradigm that Leif Weatherby has recently designated an “organological” metaphysics; the semantics of the *Bergschluchten* invokes the “Glieder” rather than the “organ,” but the reference to the organ—as element but also as phallus—is unmistakable. See Leif Weatherby, *Transplanting the Metaphysical Organ: German Romanticism between Leibniz and Marx* (New York: Fordham University Press: 2016).

²⁰Johann Gottlieb Fichte, *Grundlage der gesamten Wissenschaftslehre, Sämtliche Werke*, part 1, vol. 1, ed. J. H. Fichte (Berlin: Veit und Comp: 1845), 225.

²¹Fichte, *Grundlage der gesamten Wissenschaftslehre*, 265.

²²Compare Eibl, *Das monumentale Ich*, 306.

something to be affirmed. Redemption from this point of view has nothing to do with the utterance of the words *Verweile doch! du bist so schön!* or some variant thereof. Mephistopheles implicitly acknowledges that the wager is indeed nothing but a trick: a performative impetus that, were it to succeed, would lead Faust to confirm the ultimate futility of human endeavor—indeed, of the entire cosmological order.²³ Redemption depends on a force of affirmation rather than the fulfillment of or failure to fulfill a condition.

The absolute affirmation of processes of becoming, however, when seen from the perspective of an ontology informed by *Naturphilosophie*, can also take place outside a subject-centered framework of intelligibility. The naturephilosophical absolute points to the notion of a form of striving based not on the human will, and even less derived from a philosophy of the will that positions itself against the world or sees all otherness as something to be merely consumed and appropriated, making all foreignness (*Fremdartiges*) into that which is one's own or one's property, *Eigentum*.

Returning to the final words of the tragedy spoken by the *chorus mysticus* provides a clue in this direction. As one might expect from any discursive association with mysticism, the words of the chorus reenact a logic of the absolute, *das Unbedingte*. Here, however, we find an absolute not turned toward the subsumption and incorporation of an exteriority—that is, not an absolute *ego* of the sort that Fichte envisioned—but an absolute of attraction moving *toward* an exteriority:

Alles Vergängliche
Ist nur ein Gleichnis;
Das Unzulängliche
Hier wird's Ereignis;
Das Unbeschreibliche
Hier wird's getan;
Das Ewig-Weibliche
Zieht uns hinan. (12104–11)

These words are nothing other than a condensation of the paradoxical semantics of the absolute: that which one cannot attain manifests itself in all events, indeed in the surfaces

²³This claim is complex and requires further justification that I cannot offer in this context. Suffice it to say, scholars often obsess over the extent to which Faust expresses the desire to linger in the moment or whether he says the words—or avoids saying the words through the subjunctive—which, in any case, seems to Mephistopheles not to matter to the strategy of how he will ultimately claim Faust's soul: "Er wird Erquickung sich umsonst erflehn, / Und hätt' er sich auch nicht dem Teufel übergeben, / Er müßte doch zu Grunde gehn!" (1865–67) Mephistopheles does not need Faust to speak the words for him to be (existentially) damned. The central conflict unfolds as a question of perspective: whereas Faust sees restlessness and dissatisfaction as signs of the expansive transcendence of perpetual becoming, as activity that is worthwhile in and of itself, Mephistopheles understands this very same dynamic as culminating in futility and senselessness. The two therefore provide antinomic points of view on one and the same process of becoming. Faust's redemption depends on the extent to which his transcendence is not mere futility, and the outcome of the cosmic drama implicitly grants sheer becoming an intrinsic worth.

of sensuous appearances (*hier wird's Ereignis*); the world of appearances appears as *simile* (*Gleichnis*) with an indexical structure that points beyond itself; that which cannot be articulated is nevertheless performed, thus *unconditioning* all acts of discourse by leading them back to a non-discursive zone (*das Unbeschreibliche / hier wird's getan*); and yet all of this serves the production of an attraction, *das Ewig-Weibliche / Zieht uns hinan*. The force of this absolute of attraction is characterized by a fundamental discrepancy: the attraction system is marked by sexual difference (*das Ewig-Weibliche*) but addresses itself to an audience that is explicitly *not* marked by sexual difference. The community within the orbit of this attraction refers to the members of the chorus and presumably beyond this chorus to include androgynous angels as well as female and male figures. The pull of the Eternal Feminine cannot be reduced to simple heteronormativity.²⁴

What is performed in the *chorus mysticus* is the mysterious paradoxicality of the absolute itself: the idea that individuation, the movement from the absolute into the world of appearances and from appearances back to the absolute, structurally requires an inconsistency. This fissure in the dynamic of appearances is assured not just in the pull of attraction but in the act of striving, which becomes simply one manifestation of a more capacious ontology. Compare the gnomic utterance of the divine from *Faust I*—"Es irrt der Mensch, solang' er strebt" (317)—with the dictum of the angels: "'Wer immer strebend sich bemüht / Den können wir erlösen'" (11936–7). Whoever strives can be saved; and whoever strives is in a state of error. Those who can be saved are those who *err*. To fully grasp the implications of this cosmological order as fundamental deviation, we should not seek to resolve this tension but to deepen it, to intensify its power of contradiction. *Irren* designates not only to be wrong, but to wander: to err. The absolute is errant, and the shapes of life generative of this absolute are aberrant. One may thus conclude that the cosmological dynamic of *Faust* is predicated on the affirmation of a wandering falsehood—a point to which we will return.²⁵

However, one can go even further in the process of unconditioning by resisting the attempt to read the Eternal Feminine itself, *das Ewig-Weibliche*, as a totalizing cosmic principle. Even in the context of the drama as a whole, it constitutes one relatively homogeneous zone among others (*relatively* homogeneous inasmuch as it, too, is internally differentiated through heterogeneous elements). Every relatively homogeneous zone interacts with an exteriority to which it relates and with which it is bound up in an overarching system. Thus in the phrase the Eternal Feminine pulls "us," the attractive force becomes constitutive of this specific community, this "we," roughly designating a demarcation between those who belong inside and those who exist outside this specific field of force. By regarding *Faust* as an absolute textual system, or a textual articulation of the unconditioned, we encounter other forms of individuation: that which lies outside Faustian striving and, more significantly, outside the attractive pull of the Eternal Feminine itself, the system of salvation as presented in the mountain gorges. By attending to that which exceeds any specific manifestation of the abso-

²⁴The Eternal-Feminine reveals itself here as a queering source of individuation; compare Robert Tobin, *Warm Brothers*, 145–46.

²⁵Wellbery understands Faustian subjectivity to refer a specific form of striving: "[ein] auf den Urquell gerichtetes Streben," which "ein erhebliches Irrtumspotential in sich birgt." Wellbery, *Goethes Faust I*, 61.

lute, even the Eternal Feminine fails as a totalizing cosmological principle, since it can only appear as a particular condition of that which is unconditioned (*das Unbedingte*).

ABSOLUTE MOVEMENTS OF DISINDIVIDUATION AND HYPERINDIVIDUATION

Reading *Faust* obliquely—by turning our attention away from the figure of Faust as the dominant model of striving for the absolute—reveals the way in which non-normative or anti-normative (or in the case of Homunculus, phantasmatically unliveable) ways of being become part of the order of the text. These forms of self-assertion, or as the case may be, self-dissolution, often do not cohere with the expansive model of Fichtean striving in which alterity constitutes a threat to the self. Their transcendental ground can thus be uncovered more precisely in a naturephilosophical ontology rather than in the subject-centered action of positioning oneself (*sich setzen*) or taking a stand. Perhaps the most rapturous manifestation of a naturephilosophical ontology can be found in the figure of Homunculus, who ultimately chooses to embody himself in an elemental disembodiment or formlessness, “von Proteus verführt” (8469).²⁶ Homunculus is drawn to his end (or rather, his beginning) by an attractive force that one could subsume under the concept of the Eternal Feminine: Galatea in “Venus Muschelwagen” (8144). This erotic pull, however, does not culminate in a human form, nor in any form of individuation whatsoever. The final hymn to the elements spoken upon his transfiguration celebrates the elemental forms of formlessness: fire (*Feuer*), water (*Wasser*), waves (*Wogen*), airs (*Lüfte*), and—instead of the solidity of the earth—vaults or crypts (*Grüfte*). That the final element in this hymn, that of earth, manifests itself in the hollow spaces of the grave, *Grüfte*, reveals the extent to which Homunculus’s birth is also a death: the making-present of the absolute as an operation of indifferentiation between birth and death. Indeed, Schelling understands primordial fluidity as an “Aufhebung aller Individualität.”²⁷ In the case of Homunculus, attraction does *not* individuate, but disindividuates, initiating a process in which the absolute manifests itself as a return to an elemental matrix from which forms emerge.

A counterfigure to Homunculus is that of Euphorion. Euphorion could be considered a *hyperself*, or one who undertakes a resolutely vertical flight as opposed to the directionless fluidity of Homunculus. The allegorical nature of Euphorion—as Goethe himself suggested—establishes from the outset a form of signification in which the particular seems to manifest a generality. However, Euphorion is not a *mere* allegory for poetry, but a higher-order manifestation of an agonism of forces (and thus both allegorical and symbolic), a concrete embodiment of a transcendental order that subtends all poetic unfolding: in this instance, the naturephilosophical struggle between light and gravity, the expansive and con-

²⁶I have touched on this figure elsewhere in another context; see Gabriel Trop, “Affirmative Disequilibrium: Hogarth, Schiller, Schelling, and Goethe,” *Germanic Review* 92 (2017): 169–88.

²⁷Friedrich Schelling, *Erster Entwurf eines Systems der Naturphilosophie, Sämtliche Werke*, part 1, vol. 3, ed. Karl Friedrich August Schelling (Stuttgart and Augsburg: Cotta: 1858), 6.

tractive tendencies.²⁸ Euphorion's central gesture consists in the negation of the pull of gravity: "Ich will nicht länger / Am Boden stocken" (9722–23). Drawn to the light as that which expands outward and overcomes boundaries, his form of absolute striving is just as extreme as that of Faust: "Keine Wälle, keine Mauern, / Jeder nur sich selbst bewußt" (9855–6). As primarily consciousness, or *Bewußtsein*, he seems at first to embody the agonistic relation between self and other characteristic of Fichtean subjective striving; however, as we shall see, his particular form of striving, too, ultimately becomes *de-subjectified*.

Like the charioteer (*Knabe Lenker*)—who says, "Bin die Verschwendung, bin die Poesie" (5573)—Euphorion's assent, which grows more aggressive and transgressive as he matures, implies a conception of poetry that cannot be sublimated in the equilibrium of a process of formation or *Bildung*; it operates according to the logic of what Georges Bataille would call a general rather than a restrictive economy.²⁹ In this economy, erotic desire can become commensurate with rape, and the result of the erotic union between Faust and Helena culminates in the violence of war: "Krieg ist das Lösungswort" (9837). Like Homunculus, Euphorion renders sensuously manifest the equiprimordiality of *eros* and *thanatos*; his excessive transcendence, his extreme self-assertion, ends in a trajectory that dissolves the boundaries of the body:

Ein schöner Jüngling stürzt zu der Eltern Füßen, man glaubt in dem Toten eine bekannte Gestalt zu erblicken; doch das Körperliche verschwindet sogleich, die Aureole steigt wie ein Komet zum Himmel auf, Kleid, Mantel und Lyra bleiben liegen. (FA 1,7/1:383)

The chorus—and Faust and Helen—interpret Euphorion's flight as a failure because the body falls to the ground. The stage directions indicate, however, that we are to understand this failure as a transformation. The falling of the body is correlated with the ascension of the spirit, or yet another manifestation of the absolute of force as the overcoming of gravity. Once Euphorion leaves behind his body, he leaves behind his individuation; as if to confirm his compatibility with the sacred, what remains is his halo, *Aureole* (which Goethe understood as an emanation of a higher spiritual power), no longer subordinate to a downward pull.³⁰ With this ascension, however, the body becomes depersonalized and familiar at one and the same time: it is *eine bekannte Gestalt*. Goethe supposedly had Byron in mind with this "bekannte Gestalt"; the text itself, however, does not include this referential specificity, thereby allowing the figure to remain divested of individuality.

In a paradoxical manner, Euphorion's hyperindividuation, which sought the elimination of all boundaries to the self and within the self, leads to the destruction of the very notion of a self. The text therefore reveals on a more profound level how the particularly

²⁸Such is the central dynamic tension in Schelling's *Von der Weltseele*. If Euphorion is indeed "allegorical," in *Faust* (as an instance of the generative absolute), he becomes equally symbolic by virtue of his capacity to produce the absolute, thus indifferentiating allegory and symbol.

²⁹See Georges Bataille, *The Accursed Share: An Essay on General Economy*, vol. 1, trans. Robert Hurley (New York: Zone, 1991).

³⁰See Albrecht Schöne, *Kommentar zu Goethes Faust-Dichtung* (FA 1,7/2), 631.

poetic trajectory performed by Euphorion culminates not in the articulation or assertion of an identity but in its dissolution. The comparison of Euphorion to Icarus is made from the perspective of the chorus, or a community whose norms grasp the world through the lens of finitude: death as an end. Euphorion, however, emphatically refuses any participation in the normative structure of such a community; he posits as a goal the elimination of any and all systems of differentiation, including that of the body. To lose one's body to death from such a perspective is therefore not to fail, since the body can only exist in the form of a bounded system. Indeed, from such a point of view—which is not the view taken by the chorus—death is not a punishment for Euphorion's transgressions. Rather, Euphorion is granted that which he desired all along: an absolutization of the self that ends up being incommensurate with selfhood.

Homunculus and Euphorion represent two different possible permutations in which the absolute of force generates aberrant destinies, both of which enact dis-individuation, dissolution, or elemental indifferenciation. The very same absolute of force, however, equally saturates other notable forms of individuation that diverge in notable ways from Faustian striving. Here, I will briefly turn to the heteronomously ethical self (Margarete) and the negative (Mephistopheles).

THE HETERONOMOUS SELF AS ALTERNATIVE TO FAUSTIAN STRIVING

One of the most poignant features of the final scene in *Faust* is that it enacts a family reunion, albeit one in which the family structure is distorted and members remain separated from one another, almost as if they inhabit different worlds: Faust appears at once as father and as infant; Margarete as mother, or *Una Poenitentium sonst Gretchen gemant*; and the choir of blessed boys, according to the Pater Seraphicus, “Mitternachts Geborne, / Halb erschlossen Geist und Sinn, / Für die Eltern gleich Verlorne” (11898–900), must include among its numbers the child that Gretchen herself put to death. Father, mother, and child find themselves brought together—but strangely disjoined—in this space of terrestrial-heavenly redemption.

This constellation requires closer reflection. Let us recall that the angels single out striving (*streben*) as the key dynamic that triggers the possibility of redemption. And Faust's self-reflective self-aggrandizement, his second-order celebration of the experience of experience, confirms the mere form of striving as a criterion for redemption. Is there a way, however, in which both child and mother may also be brought under this very same concept? Indeed, if infants also qualify for redemption through an act of striving, then striving must not be limited to a principle of self-reflective consciousness but must encompass the most basic drive toward self-maintenance inherent in all appearances: the *conatus* of Spinoza. In the case of Margarete, however, one observes a more profound sense of striving: a conscious structure of self-assertion that nevertheless differs radically from the megalomania of Faustian striving.

Just as Faust's earthly existence comes to an end in a state of blindness—mistaking the sounds of the digging of his own grave for the construction of a future state—so, too, at the end of *Faust I* does Gretchen seem similarly deceived by all that she holds dear. She has transgressed against the normative codes governing both church and state, and Goethe himself had, in 1783, ratified the order of execution for Johanna Catharina Höhn for a similar

crime.³¹ The disjunction, even contradiction, between the fictional and the real ought not to be explained away. Gretchen's act must be resolutely outside the ethical; Goethe's own verdict from within the laws of the state is clear on this account. This normative transgression is, in fact, a structural requirement for the manifestation of the heterogeneous power of the aesthetic, which generates multiple and incommensurable zones (legal, ethical, theological) in a differential relation with one another. The naturephilosophical absolute can *uncondition* the laws of the state by rendering these laws no longer functional as conditions, making them *unbedingt*. The law of the state is thereby executed in one domain (in Goethe's historical reality) and suspended in another (in the work of art).

Gretchen's transgression, from the perspective of absolute semiosis, discloses a basic dynamic inherent to an ontological process of becoming; it is no longer mere aberration. Gretchen's own state of blindness and sin is sutured *into* the order of the absolute by virtue of its generative attractive and repulsive tendencies. In Gretchen's final speech act, a declaration of a lingering attachment or a tragic renunciation, she speaks her former lover's name (which may or may not be his real name): "Heinrich! Heinrich!" (4612). And yet she seems to distance herself from her attraction to Faust at this very moment. More precisely, she recoils not from Faust, but from the Mephistophelean nihilism with which Faust is associated. Following an instinctive aversion to Mephistopheles, she says:

Dein bin ich Vater! Rette mich!
Ihr Engel! Ihr heiligen Scharen,
Lagert euch umher, mich zu bewahren!
Heinrich! Mir graut's vor dir. (4607–10)

Throughout the drama, Margarete asserts her own identity in two fundamental domains: erotic love and belief in a transcendent, monotheistic—specifically, Catholic—structure of reality. Both of these tendencies must also therefore qualify her for—or at least not exclude her from—the redemptive pull of the Eternal Feminine. However, these tendencies represent distinctly non-Faustian forms of striving. In a certain sense, Margarete's redemption is as significant as that of Faust, if not more significant, precisely because it reveals striving not to be limited to a form of willing commensurate with radical autonomy, with a positing of the other as foreign, as something that must be subordinated to one's own self-reflective drive for dominion. Margarete's salvation thus points to an alternative paradigm of self-articulation in the set of striving beings.

This alternative form of striving is not based on the assertiveness of the will beyond good and evil but, on the contrary, by a form of heteronomy, or the recognition of an ethical or normative structure greater than oneself into which one must fit oneself. She signals her position within this ethical context inasmuch as she has exchanged her earlier identity as *Gretchen* with "Una poenitentum" and "Die Eine Büsserin" in the mountain gorges (the fact

³¹ For this case and the scholarly controversies surrounding it, see Rüdiger Scholz, *Das kurze Leben der Johanna Catharina Höhn. Kindesmorde und Kindesmörderinnen im Weimar Carl Augusts und Goethes. Die Akten zu den Fällen Johanna Catharina Höhn, Maria Sophia Rost und Margaretha Dorothea Altwien* (Würzburg: Königshausen and Neumann, 2004).

that these terms appear in Latin and in German binds her particular identity as German to her ethical position as Catholic). Her form of striving is also commensurate with an economy of *grace* that is itself an attraction to the other as a gift rather than the other as a threat. Addressing herself to Mary, Margarete fuses the love for Mary (divine love) with the love for Faust (erotic love):

Neige neige
 Du Ohnegleiche,
 Du Strahlenreiche,
 Dein Antlitz gnädig meinem Glück.
 Der früh Geliebte
 Nicht mehr Getrübte
 Er kommt zurück. (12069–75)

Gretchen had spoken similar words before an image of Mary as *Mater dolorosa* in *Faust I*: “Ach neige, / Du Schmerzenreiche / Dein Antlitz gnädig meiner Not!” (3617–9; a transfiguration occurs here in the shift from *schmerzenreiche* to *strahlenreiche* and *Not* to *Glück*). In sin and in salvation, Gretchen, or more appropriately, Margarete, confirms the efficacy of a movement in direct contrast to the implacable vertical trajectory and relentless pursuit of novelty characteristic of the Faustian self. She thus rediscovers in the space of redemption, in the mountain gorges, all of the commitments through which she had articulated a sense of self in the first part of the tragedy (as if every character were to occupy an afterlife commensurate with his or her particular self-constitution while alive). If Faust’s immortal member perpetuates the tendencies of his terrestrial identity by embracing perpetual motion without any lasting connection to anyone or anything, so, too, does Gretchen find her own system of values confirmed here—*her* striving in contradistinction to a Faustian striving that abhors all attachment—in her life after death.³² She too, like Faust, repeats the critical gestures of her life and death inasmuch as she does not strive to ascend, but instead calls on a higher power to descend (*neige neige*).

The Faustian drama does not reject Margarete’s ideology of erotic love and transcendent divinity as untenable—although it does embed this transcendence in a spatio-temporal immanence (both at the end of *Faust I* and *Faust II*)—since it, too, constitutes a possible form of an intrinsically immanent absolute, or a variant of the absolute of *Naturphilosophie*.³³ If Margarete finds herself in this space, she, too, must have undertaken a form of

³²See Maike Orgel, “The Faustian ‘Gretchen’: Overlooked Aspects of a Famous Male Fantasy,” *German Life and Letters* 64, no. 1 (January 2011): 43–55. Orgel goes a long way to making the claim for Margarete as a figure of “self-realisation and subsequent self-determination” (54), but tends to argue for Margarete by isolating Faustian characteristics of her personality: by making Margarete Faustian. This unwittingly posits the masculine as the ideal and then searches for a “powerful” feminine figure as a manifestation of this masculinity. I understand Margarete’s most significant self-assertion in an alternative to Faustian striving based on love and heteronomy. Heteronomy is not intended here to denigrate Margarete but, on the contrary, to foreground her capacity to stand as an alternative to the almost naturalized norms of modernity (autonomy = strong = ethical).

³³See Wellbery’s understanding of the voice from above at the end of *Faust I* as an “immanente Deutung des tragischen Prozesses.” Wellbery, *Goethes Faust I*, 90.

divinely sanctioned striving; the structure of redemption confers legitimacy on Margarete's conception of the cosmos, and it takes its place in the mountain gorges alongside Faust's perpetual self-overcoming (and, indeed, he seems to pass her by, to miss her yet again, on his way to something else, thus repeating the tragic structure of *Faust I* rather than rectifying it).

Gretchen performs a conception of selfhood that one may designate the ethical-heteronomous self, or a self that seeks legitimation not in the assertion of its own individuality but in the dependence of one's own individuation on something or someone beyond the self, something or someone higher that descends to meet the creature. The absolute as it manifests itself in *Faust*—an absolute that unfolds according to various dynamics of attraction (physical-material, erotic, theological)—is therefore *not* reducible to a radicalized autonomy, but simply designates an overarching dynamic in which multiple configurations of the sacred become possible. The naturephilosophical absolute manifests a plurality of forms of transcendence, some of which may contradict one another, but each of which is granted a space in the holistic context of beings.

The naturephilosophical absolute thus refers to a basic dynamic of attraction or repulsion, expansion or contraction, gravity or light, that produces plural, heterogeneous zones, each with their own internal consistencies and inconsistencies. This absolute is one in which no particular zone can claim the status of the absolute, but every particular nevertheless participates in, manifests, and produces the absolute. Even the Eternal Feminine expresses not a universal, ontological principle, but merely indicates one zone through which a higher-order absolute generates itself. Although this zone seems to be privileged by the text itself—as culmination—one may nevertheless uncondition this zone by foregrounding that which is external to it.

THE ABERRANT WANDERING OF THE ABSOLUTE AND THE NEGATION OF BEING

The figure that lies most decisively outside the community structured by the Eternal Feminine is Mephistopheles. And yet he, too, participates in the more fundamental dynamic of attraction; toward the end of the tragedy, in a redirection of the trajectory of Platonic Eros, he says, “Ich liebte mir dafür das Ewig-Leere” (11603). Mephistopheles, as the spirit who always negates, “der Geist der stets verneint” (1338), displays a negativity with respect to the totality of appearances; he is an appearance that indexes the void external to order as part of this order. He is not attracted to this or that particular being that he puts in relationship to an immanent-transcendent reality (Margarete), nor to an attempt to experience and encompass the totality of possible worlds in one's own subjectivity (Faust), but to the nothingness of beings as such. He stands for all subjects who lie outside any given order, and his presence generates a counternormative force against all forms of sacrality, consistence, coherence, transcendence, or normative stability (hence Margarete's natural aversion to Mephistopheles).

Mephistopheles nevertheless has a critical function in the order and disorder of textual appearances: he gives the lie to any attempt to totalize the Eternal Feminine as an absolute ontology. As one who is *not* drawn by the Eternal Feminine, he displays a homoerotics of attraction. As he is preparing to take Faust's soul, he finds himself erotically distracted

by the angels. As W. Daniel Wilson has noticed, he recasts these angels—androgynous or hermaphroditic beings—as objects of homosexual desire: he asks them, “Seid ihr nicht auch von Luzifers Geschlecht?” (11770).³⁴ His desire becomes homoerotic in the sense that he is attracted to his own race or sex, *Geschlecht*. He says again: “Sie wenden sich — Von hinten anzusehen! — / Die Racker sind doch gar zu appetitlich” (11799–1800). And yet the erotic pull of the angels is not merely homoerotic: it is an attraction to beings that destabilize sexual differentiation as such.

Mephistopheles' form of desire, while commensurate with the movements of attraction, presents itself as an exception to the seemingly totalizing claim of the Eternal Feminine. Mephistopheles thus performs attraction as a potentially extra-normative realm exempted from divine striving, indicative of the tendency toward nothingness or a counterforce to the demands of Being. As the functionalization of the part that cannot be assimilated to the whole and yet is indifferentiated with the whole, he most clearly embodies the paradoxical semantics of the absolute, or, as he describes himself, “Teil des Teils, der Anfangs alles war” (1349). By negating the very notion of a totalizing redemptive system, Mephistopheles keeps the system in a state of perpetually dynamic motion; he exerts a relativizing force over any particular domain that wishes to claim for itself the status of absolute totality.

Mephistopheles, as that exteriority or chaotic reserve internal to order, moves according to an attractive force that undermines the supposedly homogeneous and universalizing ontological framework of the Eternal Feminine—which, as we have shown, harbors its own inconsistencies and is not reducible to a purely heteronormative pull. The functionalization of Mephistopheles as the principle of negation in the total order of the text should not be confused with a Hegelian rehabilitation of the negative within an overarching dialectical process.³⁵ On the contrary, Mephistopheles, as an agent of unconditioning, occupies a position from which the fundamental untruth of the cosmic system can reveal itself, or a position from which every particular element or domain in the cosmic system is understood as a failed attempt to represent the absolute in its totality (but nevertheless is simultaneously accorded a revelatory truth value inasmuch as every element belongs inextricably to the absolute as becoming). If it is true that the divine is nothing other than the unfolding of an inconsistent system; if it is true that *all* striving is commensurate with redemption (*‘Wer immer strebend sich bemüht / Den können wir erlösen’*); and if it is true that the human being is perpetually false or wandering in a state of striving (*Es irrt der Mensch, solang’ er strebt*), it follows that redemption itself is nothing other than a falsehood and a wandering: *irren*.

Readers of *Faust* may thus find themselves in an oscillation between two limit points of interpretive possibility, each of which are equally problematic, and thus equally tragic in a certain sense: the affirmation of a non-totalizing, heterogeneous, potentially destructive

³⁴As W. Daniel Wilson writes: “Der Höhepunkt der Szene erfüllt demnach nicht das ‘homosexuelle’ Begehren, sondern treibt die Zweideutigkeit auf die Spitze, mit der alle klaren Unterscheidungen verloren gehen.” W. Daniel Wilson, *Goethe Männer Knaben* (Berlin: Insel, 2012), 334.

³⁵Jeffrey Champlin discusses precisely the differences and tensions between Hegel and Goethe, writing, “Amid the blossoming systems of metaphysics around 1800, Goethe brings to the stage not only a warning against this drive’s formal tendency to withdraw into itself but also a demand from the victims in its path.” Jeffrey Champlin, “Hegel’s *Faust*,” *Goethe Yearbook* 18 (2013): 115–25, 123.

and agonistic order of appearances, or the negation of this very same order. The tragedy of *Faust* is perhaps most acutely felt by hovering between the irrepressible desire to affirm the catastrophic structure of life and an equiprimordial ethical impulse to negate the structure of catastrophe. To say yes to the cosmological order made visible in the mountain gorges entails an affirmation of every act of violence, dissolution, and domination (Faust's relation to Margarete, his treatment of Baucis and Philemon, Euphorion's celebration of rape and violence) as ultimately co-extensive with the attraction of the Eternal Feminine. To say no to the Eternal Feminine would entail a rejection of the erotic *and* the agonistic elements through which being discloses itself: to say no to the system of life as a whole, to the extent that this system legitimizes or normalizes trauma, death, and dominion.

The logic upon which Mephistopheles operates—the desire to negate the attractive power of the Eternal Feminine, a power with which so much injustice and violence is wholly commensurable—thus takes the form of a judgment against life. If life is irrevocably contaminated by the violence of becoming, it is perhaps better to do away with it completely, or as Mephistopheles says, “alles was entsteht / Ist wert daß es zu Grunde geht; / Drum besser wär's daß nichts entstünde” (1339–41). Mephistopheles assigns value from the standpoint of a nothingness that lies outside all normativity. Indeed, for a figure who resolutely occupies the position of negation, there can be no positive ethics at all; the central function of this figure is to prevent anything resembling a closed and static system with a seemingly incontestable normative foundation from remaining operative indefinitely. Mephistopheles thus takes up arms with the force of the negative against a different sort of violence than the violence of life, namely, the violence of the attempt to make a totalizing system perfectly consistent with itself. In this very gesture, we come face to face with a paradoxical conclusion: if an attraction to ethics were to be found in Goethe's *Faust*, one of its most uncompromising possible iterations would belong to Mephistopheles.